

Strange pollinators

Many flowers are pollinated by bees and butterflies (p. 22), but some plant species depend on quite different creatures for pollination. Some are pollinated by the kind of flies that are attracted by the smell of decay. Others rely on birds, which are attracted to the flowers by bright colors and the sweet smell of nectar. Many plants are highly adapted for specific pollinators. The list of these species includes not only insects and birds, but also bats, mice, possums, and even slugs.

DISAPPEARING TRICK

One rare orchid, from Western Australia, spends almost all of its life under ground. It has no leaves, and its flowers grow in cup-shaped clusters that open just level with the surface. The flowers attract termites, gnats, and other insects that help to spread their pollen. After producing their seeds, the flowers wither away, and the orchid disappears below ground once again.



Flowers are lilac at first, but turn red as they open

Pink bracts attract birds

Hairs on the petals attract insects

Shiny surface attracts flies

Cultivated fly-pollinated orchid

Flowers appear among the bracts

A LURE FOR FLIES
Bees are attracted to flowers that have a sweet smell. Many flies, on the other hand, are attracted by the smell of decaying flesh. For this reason, many flowers that rely on flies for pollination have a putrid odor. Some flowers, such as this orchid, have hairs on the surface of their petals to give them an animal-like feel. The shiny surface also attracts flies.

THE RED SIGNAL

Plants that are pollinated by birds often have red or pink petals or flower heads. Birds have excellent color vision, and a bright red flower, which also produces nectar, readily attracts them. Because this urn plant is one of many plant species that live high up on trees (p. 46), it needs to be conspicuous to attract the attention of the bird pollinators. Most insects, aside from some butterflies, cannot see red, so it is an unusual color for an insect-pollinated flower.

Urn plant